Identifying students' language and learning support needs

Practical guide for institutions | I02

Establish a coordinated process for identifying students' language and learning support needs at entry, during transition and as course demands change. Combine student input, educator observations and appropriate specialist evidence so that identified needs inform individual support and program planning.

Using this guide: Build this work into existing induction, diagnostic, academic advising and progress-monitoring processes. It does not replace institutional admissions, assessment or support procedures. Educators contribute evidence from teaching; the institution provides the coordination, specialist access and resources needed to interpret and act on it.

1. Assign coordination and specialist responsibilities

Name the program or service lead responsible for coordinating identification. Agree the roles of subject educators, language specialists, advisers and relevant services, including who reviews evidence and who authorises further specialist assessment.

Give educators clear guidance on what to notice and how to raise concerns. They should not be expected to diagnose language proficiency from classroom performance. Allocate time and specialist capacity rather than relying on individual initiative.

2. Agree when identification will take place

Plan suitable points within existing processes: entry and induction, early course learning, transitions to more demanding tasks, and reviews when difficulties persist. Provide a route for students to raise needs at any time.

Use admission evidence as one input. Meeting an entry requirement does not establish readiness for every disciplinary task, and a score alone does not explain a current difficulty. Avoid unnecessary repeat testing; agree what additional information is needed and why.

3. Combine evidence relevant to program demands

Subject educators and language specialists should agree the language and academic demands of representative course tasks. Use this shared understanding to interpret existing information, including student accounts, observations, samples of work and relevant diagnostic findings.

For example, evidence may concern following explanations, interpreting assessment requirements or explaining disciplinary reasoning. Classroom tasks can contribute evidence without becoming a separate testing system. Where further language assessment is needed, involve appropriately qualified specialists and explain its purpose and use.

Consider unclear teaching, unfamiliar subject knowledge, academic practices and inaccessible resources alongside English-language needs. Do not infer needs from ethnicity, accent or home language, or label a difficulty as a language deficit without sufficient evidence.

4. Make identification accessible to ethnic-minority students

Explain how students can raise concerns privately, what information is sought and what will happen next. Consult students about useful ways to contribute; do not require them to represent a community or disclose personal background to justify a difficulty.

Where English proficiency is not being assessed, institutional guidance should permit appropriate ways to clarify subject understanding, including relevant ethnic-minority languages, diagrams or practical demonstrations. Vietnamese may also help but should not be assumed to be everyone's strongest language. Avoid blanket English-only restrictions in these diagnostic activities.

Arrange appropriate language support or other checks of meaning where staff do not understand the chosen language. Do not assume classmates can interpret sensitive information. Where English performance is the focus, make its purpose and requirements explicit and follow approved assessment arrangements.

5. Record findings and connect them to action

Agree a proportionate record of the identified need, evidence, action owner and review point. Explain how information will be used and follow institutional requirements for consent, confidentiality and access.

Distinguish needs requiring teaching or resource improvement from those requiring academic skills support, specialist language assessment or other services. Confirm who will coordinate the next step. I03 sets out student support pathways; I07 addresses responsibility and referral arrangements.

Identification should lead to a response. If appropriate provision is unavailable, record and escalate the gap to the responsible lead rather than repeatedly asking the student or educator to seek help elsewhere.

6. Use patterns to improve provision

Review whether the identification process reaches students, whether findings are sufficiently clear to guide action and whether agreed responses occur. Revisit needs as tasks change or difficulties persist.

Use recurring findings across courses to inform program planning, staff development, resource access and support capacity through existing review cycles. Report patterns without identifying individuals or treating ethnicity as an explanation for performance. I08 provides guidance on broader monitoring.

7. Example coordinating identification across a first-year program

A program receives repeated reports that students struggle with readings and written recommendations. Its existing entry process records English scores, but there is no agreed way to bring student concerns and course evidence together.

The program lead agrees a review process with advisers, subject educators and a language specialist. Students can describe difficulties privately; educators contribute relevant work samples and observations. The team distinguishes inaccessible readings and unclear task expectations from needs requiring further academic or language support.

The program assigns owners to resolve shared barriers and coordinates individual next steps through existing support pathways. At an agreed review point, it checks whether students reached the provision and uses recurring unmet needs to inform program resourcing.

8. Review checklist

☐ A named lead coordinates identification and specialist input.

☐ Identification is planned at entry, transition and later points of need.

☐ Student input and course evidence are considered alongside entry information.

☐ Educators receive guidance and are not expected to make specialist diagnoses.

☐ Ethnic-minority languages and accessible ways to contribute are considered.

☐ Findings have an action owner, appropriate record and review point.

☐ Unmet needs and recurring patterns inform institutional decisions.

9. When further institutional action is needed

Escalate unclear responsibilities, unavailable specialist assessment, inaccessible identification processes or repeated needs without a response. Program and institutional leaders should address capacity and provision gaps. Identifying more students as needing help is not sufficient if there is no accessible response.

10.Related toolkit guidance

I01: program design and review. I03: student support pathways. I04–I05: educator development. I06: resources. I07: responsibilities and referrals. I08: monitoring. Educator guides provide classroom strategies; student guides D16–D17 support sharing preferences and seeking help.

11.Supporting sources

Galloway, N., & Sahan, K. (2021). An investigation into English Medium Instruction in higher education in Thailand and Vietnam. British Council. Open source

Section 9, especially “Entrance requirements” and “Language support”, supports considering discipline-specific demands and informing support through institutional and departmental needs analysis. It does not validate the diagnostic activities proposed here.

University of Minnesota, College of Continuing & Professional Studies. (n.d.). Fostering a Linguistically Inclusive and Asset-Based Classroom. Open source

The “Helpful Tips” section supports recognising linguistic resources, shared communicative responsibility and opportunities to engage with content using different languages. The focus on ethnic-minority languages in Vietnamese higher education is a toolkit adaptation.

Galloway, N. (Ed.). (2020). English in higher education – English medium. Part 1: Literature review. British Council. Open source

Pages 44–48 support context-specific needs analysis, ongoing consultation and support informed by the demands students encounter. These principles inform this guide; the report does not validate its diagnostic activities.

The review often discusses a shared local language. Applying its principles to ethnic-minority languages in Vietnam requires attention to students' actual language repertoires; Vietnamese should not be assumed to be everyone's strongest language.

The coordination process, example, checklist and arrangements for recording and acting on findings are toolkit adaptations. Sources support particular principles rather than the complete guide. This guide is not a validated language assessment or institutional diagnostic model. Its application with ethnic-minority students requires local consultation and evaluation. Developing draft for review.